AI ETHICS PORTFOLIO · VADEMECUM IV

# Seven Hours to a New Life

*On AI washing, and the monetisation of displacement anxiety*

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THE ADVERTISEMENT

# One film, two protagonists

### The manager

He managed a team once. The company restructured, the function was automated, and now he drives for a rideshare app. What he lost was standing.

### The housewife

Her husband has gone. She has no income of her own, no recent employer, and a household that still costs what it cost. What she lost was shelter.

Neither protagonist is lazy and neither is unqualified. The film is careful that you understand this. A buyer who feels at fault feels shame, and shame does not convert. A buyer who feels displaced feels owed, and restitution can be sold.

THE TEMPLATE

# Not two sellers. A specification.

THE PHRASE THE SELLERS USE

## "*AI anxiety*"

The marketing names the emotion it is selling to, unprompted, in its own copy.

### ONE SPECIFICATION

15 minutes a day and 28 days recur across unrelated sellers, alongside the same opening quiz and the same certificate at the end.

### ONE CAPTURED REVIEW LAYER

Search for an independent review and the leading results are sites built around the product category itself, carrying affiliate links.

### ONE SHARED PROTAGONIST

The woman returning to work after years away appears in seller after seller, under a different name each time.

A question worth asking rather than asserting: a 28 day programme ends a few days before a monthly renewal falls due. The buyer finishes, disengages, and is billed for something already over.

Phrasing and structure recurring across current providers; sources on file with the author



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THE ARITHMETIC THE FILM PERFORMS BUT NEVER STATES

# Seven hours

15 minutes a day for 28 days is seven hours in total. Seven hours of study between the rideshare seat and the successful company.

In its daily denomination it sounds modest. As a total, nobody believes it for a moment, so it is never given as a total. Fifteen minutes is not a claim about outcomes. It is the removal of the last honest reason to decline.

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## THE PRODUCT

The course is the pretext. The flow is the product.

### The quiz

A few questions, then a plan described as yours. Flattery, invoiced later.

### The anchor

A first price cut so far that the card, not the course, is what is bought.

### The bumps

Extra reports offered at checkout, each click reading as a confirmation.

### The default

Renewal on, at a multiple of the entry price, disclosed where disclosure is technically true.

### The exit

Cancellation available, several screens away, to whoever keeps looking.

Not one step of this requires artificial intelligence. Not one is improved by it. Churn is not a failure of the model. It is the model.

Pattern names follow the taxonomy in Mathur et al. (2019)



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THE EVIDENCE BASE

# Documented, measured, already named

| Source | What it establishes |
|---|---|
| Mathur et al. (2019) | A crawl of roughly 11,000 shopping sites and 53,000 product pages found 1,818 deceptive design instances on 1,254 of them, sorted into 15 types across 7 categories. |
| Brignull (2010), in Mathur et al. (2019) | The term dark patterns, for interface choices that benefit the service by steering, coercing or deceiving the person using it. |
| Luguri and Strahilevitz (2021) | An experimental and doctrinal study of how far these designs move behaviour, and which legal instruments already reach them. |

The mechanism is neither novel nor obscure. What is new here is only the costume it wears.



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# Ethics washing, inverted

### Ethics washing

"*the malpractice of making unsubstantiated or misleading claims about, or implementing superficial measures in favour of, the ethical values and benefits of digital processes, products, services, or other solutions*"

Floridi (2019, p. 187). It borrows credibility from a moral vocabulary and returns nothing to it.

### AI washing

*The same manoeuvre rotated: superficial claims about the transformative value of a technology, made in order to appear more technological than one is.*

It borrows credibility from a technical vocabulary and returns nothing to it.

Not opposites. Mirrors. One uses the language of restraint to avoid restraining anything, the other the language of transformation to avoid transforming anything. Both import legitimacy from a domain the audience cannot audit, and both spend it.

Left definition quoted from Floridi (2019, p. 187); right definition is this deck's own construction



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## THE ANALYTICAL SPINE

Responsibility follows knowledge, choice and agency

### What the seller knows

- The completion rate of the course
- The refund rate and the churn curve
- The conversion lift of every upsell
- The share who never open it again

### What the buyer knows

A story about a man in a car.

The test usually distributes responsibility along a chain. Here it does not distribute at all. The asymmetry is not a background condition of commerce that the seller inherited: it was built, tested and kept, because the tested alternative converted worse. Strip it out and there is nothing left to sell.



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THE HARM

# The harm that is not the money

### Recoverable

A subscription fee. Unpleasant, sometimes materially painful, bounded, and refundable in principle by whoever keeps asking.

### Unrecoverable

A person who correctly identified a real risk to their livelihood, and acted on it, has been sold a placebo and now believes the risk is addressed. The money set aside for retraining is spent, and so is the motivation, which is scarcer than the money. When the displacement arrives they will meet it holding a certificate that signifies nothing, having already tried. The second attempt is always harder than the first.

Those most exposed to automation are least equipped to tell genuine AI education from its costume, and so are sorted into the fraudulent tier of a market whose honest tier is reserved for people who already know enough not to need rescuing. The literacy gap does not merely persist. It is monetised on the way past.

THE ENFORCEABILITY TEST

# A principle that cannot be enforced is decoration

## Already unlawful, in pieces

ROSCA, section 5 of the FTC Act, state automatic renewal statutes, and EU and UK consumer law all reach parts of this conduct.

## Why it does not bite

Losses too small to litigate, operators dissolvable in an afternoon, payments handled as merchant disputes, and redress that reaches whoever pushes hardest.

## Two that would

Accountability at the payment processor, which sees the refund outlier first. And a total cost and total time figure, stated as totals, wherever an outcome is claimed.

Enforcement that reliably refunds the persistent and never reaches the flow is not enforcement. It is a rebate on being difficult.

The US negative option rule was vacated on procedural grounds in July 2025 and the rulemaking restarted in March 2026 (FTC, 2026). Statutory enforcement never stopped.



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AI is what is being sold. The fear of AI is what is being farmed. The people paying are the ones our AI policy discourse says it is worried about.

If that discourse has nothing to say here, it should be clearer about whom it is for.

# References


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